

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Module 5 | 20 Marks

Part A – Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is one of the most common cybercrimes targeting college students and young adults in India. This case study describes a realistic scenario based on widely reported patterns.

Scenario: A second-year engineering student in Pune received a WhatsApp message from an unknown number claiming to be from the 'VIT Scholarship Cell.' The message stated that a scholarship amount of Rs. 8,000 had been approved and that the student needed to accept it by scanning a QR code. Excited and in need of money, the student scanned the code using Google Pay. Instead of receiving money, Rs. 8,000 was debited from their account. When they tried to contact the sender, the number was blocked.

How it happened (step-by-step):

- The attacker identified the target — a first-year student active on college social media groups.
- They crafted a convincing message using official-sounding terminology ('Scholarship Cell') and a plausible amount.
- The student was sent a QR code — in UPI, scanning a QR code is a payment action, not a receipt action. The fraudster exploited this confusion.
- Once the QR code was scanned and the student entered their UPI PIN, the money was immediately transferred out.
- The attacker blocked the victim and disappeared.

Who is targeted: Students, first-time UPI users, people in financial need, and anyone unfamiliar with how payment QR codes work.

Consequences: Financial loss (often non-recoverable immediately), emotional distress, and loss of trust in digital payments. In some cases, victims delay reporting, reducing the chance of recovery.

Source: Pattern based on documented cases reported by the Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) and news coverage by The Hindu and NDTV (2022–2024).

Part B – Stay Safe Online: Prevention Checklist

The following checklist (also available as `prevention-checklist.md` in `task-5-cybercrime/`) provides 8 actionable tips for college students in India:

- Never scan a QR code to 'receive' money — in UPI, QR codes are for sending money, not receiving it. Anyone asking you to scan to collect a payment is attempting fraud.
- Never share your UPI PIN, OTP, or bank password with anyone — not even someone claiming to be from your bank, college, or government.
- Verify scholarship or job offers by calling the official institution number before taking any action online.
- Use two-factor authentication (2FA) on all important accounts — email, social media, and banking apps.
- Do not click links in WhatsApp or SMS messages from unknown numbers, especially those promising prizes, jobs, or financial benefits.
- Keep your phone's OS and apps updated — security patches fix known vulnerabilities that fraudsters exploit.
- Use strong, unique passwords for different accounts. Consider using a password manager.
- Lock your SIM card with a PIN so that even if your phone is stolen, fraudsters cannot carry out SIM swap attacks.

Reporting Channels:

- National Cyber Crime Portal: cybercrime.gov.in — Report online financial fraud, cyberbullying, and other cybercrimes.
- Cyber Crime Helpline: 1930 (24x7) — Call immediately if you have lost money to online fraud; early reporting improves recovery chances.

Reflection

What surprised me most while researching this topic was how sophisticated the social engineering tactics are — the fraudsters do not need technical hacking skills. They rely entirely on exploiting trust, urgency, and a lack of awareness about how payment systems work. The QR code confusion (most people assume scanning = receiving) is a particularly effective trap because it exploits a genuine gap in digital literacy. One habit I will personally change as a result of this task is to always verify any financial request through an official channel before acting — no matter how legitimate it looks. I will also remind family members about UPI QR code safety, since they are equally if not more vulnerable.